robbed en route by Punjabi footpads, along with an assortment of items from the bag of the assistant doctor accompanying the party: ‘The stomach pump was cut to pieces by the thieves – such a blessing for Ranjit’s courtiers,’ wrote Emily when she heard of the robbery. ‘He tries all medical experiments on the people about him. How they would have been pumped!’[114]

On 20 May, Macnaghten crossed into Sikh territory. Ranjit Singh, as was his custom, received the Embassy at his favourite summer palace at Adinagar. Osborne described how Ranjit received them:

> cross-legged in a golden chair, dressed in simple white, wearing no ornaments but a single string of enormous pearls round the waist, and the celebrated Koh-i-Noor, on his arm – the jewel rivalled, if not surpassed, in brilliancy by the glance of fire which every now and then shot from his single eye as it wandered restlessly round the circle. On Ranjit sitting, his chiefs all squatted around his chair, with the exception of Dheean Singh [his eldest son] who remained standing behind his master. Though far removed from being handsome himself, Ranjit appears to take pride in being surrounded by good-looking people, and I believe few, if any other courts either in Europe or the East, could shew such a fine looking set of men as the principal Sikh sardars.

As was also Ranjit Singh’s custom, he then proceeded to interrogate his visitors: ‘Our time was principally occupied in answering Ranjit’s innumerable questions,’ wrote Osborne,

> but without the slightest chance of satisfying his curiosity. It is hardly possible to give an idea of the ceaseless rapidity with which his questions flow, or the infinite variety they embrace: ‘Do you drink wine?’ ‘How much?’ ‘Did you taste the wine which I sent you yesterday?’ ‘How much of it did you drink?’ ‘What artillery have you brought with you?’ ‘Have they got any shells?’ ‘How many?’ ‘Do you like riding on horseback?’ ‘What country horses do you prefer?’ ‘Are you in the army?’ ‘What do you like best, cavalry or infantry?’ ‘Does Lord Auckland drink wine?’ ‘How many glasses?’ ‘Does he drink it in the morning?’ ‘What is the strength of the Company’s army?’ ‘Are they well disciplined?’ After passing upwards of an hour in conversation, Ranjit Singh rose, and, according to custom, having half smothered us with sandal-wood oil, embraced and allowed us to depart . . .[115]

One subject that fascinated the Maharajah in particular was the private life of the British, and as the negotiations got under way the handsome Captain Osborne had to go through intermittent grillings on his sexual preferences:

> ‘Did you see my Cachmerian girls?’ ‘How did you like them?’ ‘Are they handsomer than the women of Hindostan?’ ‘Are they as handsome as English women?’ ‘Which of them did you admire most?’ I replied that I admired them all very much, and named the two I thought